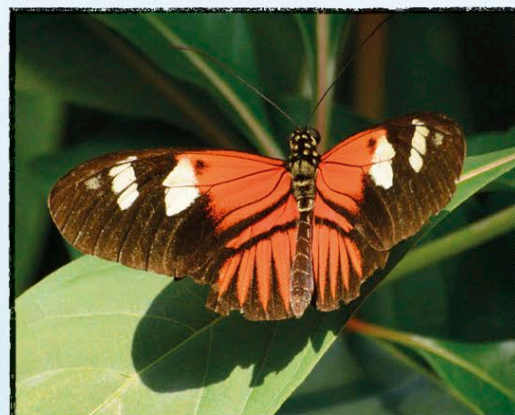


Amazon Basin

Across the lowlands of the great Amazon River Basin, local postman butterflies often live along rivers and streams. Here, they have white patches on their forewings, sometimes broken into spots.

Wings at rest

Like most day-flying butterflies, postman butterflies rest with their wings raised so their tips almost touch. Flapping their wings helps spread a scent that deters predators.



Master mimics

Closely related to the postman butterfly, the red postman (above) is a separate species, but matches the local color pattern of the postman wherever it lives alongside it. As they are both poisonous, this mimicry reinforces the warning for potential predators and helps both species survive.

KEY

 Postman butterfly range

Wetlands

In Brazil's Pantanal wetlands, the postman lives near water. Here it has white stripes on the hindwings, looking more like those along Brazil's southwest coast and in Central America.



Sucking nectar

Butterflies have a flexible tube called a proboscis for drinking liquid nectar from flowers. Usually kept coiled up, it unrolls when the butterfly is ready to feed.

Passion flower

Wing pattern

The colors of the postman butterfly come from tiny pigmented scales that cover the surface of the two pairs of wings. Its wingspan can measure up to 3 in (7.5 cm).